

thrust into a carriage so that sometimes they hardly find room to stand and breathe freely". Overcrowding was an issue and it often led to large number of deaths in high summers.

Passengers were often locked inside carriages when the train stopped at stations, thus restricting their access to water, food, or the lavatory. Some railway companies also seated passengers, especially pilgrims holding third-class tickets, in goods wagons.

Extreme discomfort

The problem was compounded by the lack of toilets, an issue that came to the fore during the 1882 Railway Conference. A variety of "reasons" were cited for not providing the facilities. Some argued that excreta would be "perpetually falling from the closets in such volumes as to befoul the line and frighten off the gang men." Others spoke of how this could be a source of danger to health, lead to an increase in labour to clean the permanent way, and even "considerable expenditure". The change began after 1902 when these facilities were finally added to third-class carriages.

Comparative luxury

European and Eurasian passengers able to pay for first- and second-class tickets seemingly travelled in the lap of luxury. British educationalist Oscar Browning in his book *Impressions of Indian Travel* (1903) noted the first-class experience: "Soda water is offered to you just as you are conceiving the wish for it. Tea comes to you punctually at 6am ... No sooner have you passed your hand over your stubby beard than a barber appears to shave you in the carriage. You get a 'little breakfast' of eggs and bacon, with bananas and oranges at eight, a delightful tiffin in the heat of noon, and a good dinner at sunset."

The spacious compartments had lower and foldable upper berths, an attached lavatory, a shower or sometimes a bath, and a small servant room. Continuous attempts were made to upgrade these facilities. During the 1870s, oil lamps were replaced by gas lamps, followed by electric lights in the early 1900s. Special attention was paid to cooling systems, given the long summers in India.